It was always going to be a life with animals. There was no plan B. "Never," he says. "I'm totally obsessed. Still."

India was home then, as it is now, and there's no sense of the white boy feeling like an outsider. "I just felt totally normal and totally part of India," says Whitaker, who speaks Hindi and Tamil. "Sometimes I look in the mirror and say God, there's a white guy! I naturally vibed with India and remained that way."

After finishing school, Whitaker took a year off and joined a taxidermist in Mysore, then worked at a farm run by a German priest in Tamil Nadu. He moved back to the US for college, but dropped out after a year ("academics sucks").

ROMULUS WHITAKER, often known affectionately as the 'Snakeman of India', is among the country's best-known conservationists

A string of odd jobs followed—snake-catcher, travelling salesman, sailor. The most memorable patch of his adolescent years are from snake-hunting in Arizona and Florida, and working in a serpentarium. "I like being in the wilds alone. I don't like talking to people," he says. One friend even tells him: you seem to like snakes more than people.

"I probably keep repeating the same thing, but they're utterly fascinating," he says. "They're utterly alien to everything else that you see around you. In a way [the fascination] also fed my ego because I was fascinated with something that other people were scared to death of or hated."

In the introduction, the authors clarify this is an autobiography rather than a memoir. "In my understanding, a memoir has a very sharp focus," says Lenin. "You write a memoir about a particular thing rather than every single detail of your life. So, he could have written a memoir as a snake person, in which case, half the book that you read would be irrelevant."

The full story includes Whitaker's seemingly incongruous passion for hunting, at one point "really rabid". "By revealing my bloody hands and early love of destruction, whether it be of animal life or explosives, you, the reader, can see the real me with all the warts," he writes. But, as he points out, he was not the only one.

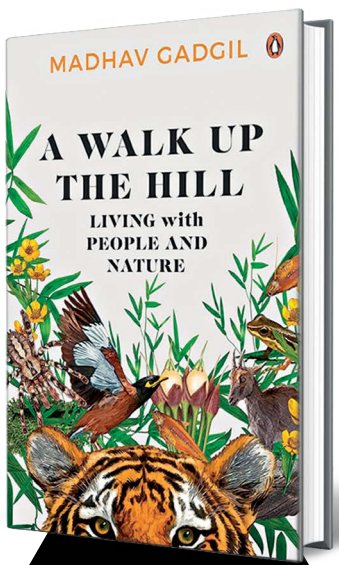
"I think if you look at all the people who made that switch from hunting to conservation, they all were hunters because that was the tradition of their fathers and their grandfathers, so they were out in the wild," says Lenin. "And then the wild works its magic on you. And then you say, 'Oh, this [species] is having a problem and maybe you shouldn't hunt it so much anymore', and then you start changing. That's possibly what happened for that generation."

The book was written over four years, with Lenin helping shape the narrative. "Janaki will gladly edit stuff and chuck it out," says Whitaker. "She's a trained film editor. For better or for worse, she's gotten rid of a lot of junk. We've tried to keep focused on the more interesting stuff."

And there's plenty to be had. Even as he details these varied experiences Whitaker constantly flirts with death and danger—rampaging elephants, irritable cobras, stray gunshots from irresponsible humans. Sometimes the bildungsroman reads more like a survival saga or a cautionary tale. He agrees that he often feels "pretty lucky" to be alive.

And for getting to live this extraordinary life. "Man, did I luck out," he says. "From the moment I was born." ■

–Bhavya Dore



A WALK UP THE HILL
Living with People and Nature
by Madhav Gadgil
PENGUIN ALLEN LANE
₹999; 412 pages

Gadgil decries the decadent "superstructure called the forest department", which continues to control people's rights to traditional grazing lands and criminalise their longstanding subsistence practices.

While studying for a master's degree in zoology at the University of Bombay in 1965, he met and married Sulochana, a fellow student and soon-to-be eminent meteorologist. Both were accepted on scholarship for postgraduate programmes at Harvard. In 1973, on his return to India, Gadgil joined the Indian Institute of Science in Bangalore. During a distinguished tenure, he established the Centre of Theoretical Studies and the Centre for Ecological Studies. His accounts of this time are replete with admiration for the institution's visionary director, Satish Dhawan.

However, Gadgil sharply critiques the culture of indolence and subservience within Indian scientific institutions, emphasising their inclination towards subpar imitative research. He doesn't hold back in his condemnation of institutions perpetuating the exclusionary mindset inherited from colonial predecessors. An exemplary case is the Bombay Natural History Society, which he labels as a "society of imperialists for imperialists by imperialists".

Gadgil's legacy is significantly tied to his role in the Western Ghats Ecology Expert Panel, which proposed identifying 64 per cent of the Western Ghats as ecologically sensitive, facing backlash. The Kasturirangan Committee, which replaced it, reduced the sensitive areas to a compromising 37 per cent, laying bare a struggle where development took precedence over environmental concerns.

Rooted in his pioneering work, Gadgil's memoir offers a thought-provoking narrative that challenges India's ecological priorities amid the threat of climate change. Despite its length, the book provides a rich account of the author's encounters with people, nature and cultures, exposing administrative corruption and a compliant bureaucracy. The narrative, likely compiled from extensive notes, suffers from repetitions of names, introductions and events that a more adept editing process could have rectified. ■

–Bijoy Venugopal